

Week 5 / Tuesday

Rick Wysocki

Dates/Context

- ▶ 1942 – 2004
- ▶ Born in the Texas borderlands
- ▶ Not formally trained as an academic until earning a PhD
- ▶ Interested in the concept of “Mestiza Consciousness”

Anzaldúa



Figure: Gloria Anzaldúa.

Key Terms

- ▶ Mestizo/Mestiza: A person of mixed descent from both Spanish and Indigenous American backgrounds.
- ▶ Chicano/a: Individuals of Mexican/Indigenous descent. Originally a slur (1940s) but reclaimed as a political term in Chicano movements of the 1960s.
- ▶ Chicana Feminism: a movement spearheaded by Anzaldúa to consider the role of women and LGBTQ mestizaje.

Anzaldúa's Key Concerns

- ▶ Latina Feminism
- ▶ Cultural Hybridity/"In-Betweenness"
- ▶ Code Meshing/The value of multiple languages
- ▶ Cultural difference

Latina Feminism

- ▶ Extends at least as far back as the late 1970s.
- ▶ Examines the intersectional role of gender, sexuality, and race for people of Latin descent.

Intersectionality

[T]he interconnected nature of social categorizations such as race, class, and gender as they apply to a given individual or group, regarded as creating overlapping and interdependent systems of discrimination or disadvantage.
– Oxford Dictionary

Intersectionality

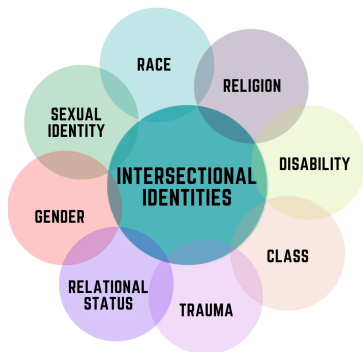


Figure: Elements often associated with intersectionality.

Code Switching/Code Meshing

- ▶ Code Switching: alternating languages or varieties of a language based on audience and context.
- ▶ Code Meshing: the practice of combining multiple language varieties within a single context.

Cultural Difference/Hybridity

Taken together, Anzaldúa's work stands testimony to her personal triumph over the "tradition of silence" and to her ability to imagine, enact, and inhabit spaces that go beyond dichotomies of all kinds: beyond male/female; beyond reason/ emotion; beyond gay/straight; beyond other/white; beyond mythic/real; beyond mind/body; beyond spirit/matter; beyond orality/literacy; beyond I/you. In every case, Anzaldua rejects either/or in favor of both/and then some, of an identity that is always in process.

– Andrea Lunsford

The Value of Difference

In these moments [of engaging/embracing cultural difference], it is possible to take in the labels of society and to transform them, to find all others in one's self; one's self in all others. Learning to live such transformations calls for a "new mestiza" who has "a tolerance for contradictions, a tolerance for ambiguity," who "learns to be an Indian in Mexican culture, to be Mexican from an Anglo point of view.

– Andrea Lunsford

The Value of Difference

I think that the only recourse is a kind of vicarious move of immersing themselves in the texts of people who are different, because the fastest way for them to recognize that they have diversity, that they have these values, that they have these experiences and beliefs, is to jerk them out into another country where they don't speak the language, they don't know the food. . . . There's something very seductive about fitting in, and being part of this one culture, and forgetting differences, and going with the way of the norm.

– Anzaldúa

Relevance to Student Writing

And especially in composition these rules are very strict: creating a thesis sentence, having some kind of argument, having kind of a logical step-by-step progression, using certain methods, like contrast, like deductive versus inductive thinking. I mean all the way back to Aristotle and Cicero. . . . But then I have to weigh things: OK, if I write in this style and I code-switch too much and I go into Spanglish too much and I do an associative kind of logical progression in a composition, am I going to lose those people that I want to affect, to change? Am I going to lose the respect of my peers—who are other writers and other artists and other academicians—when I change too much? When I change not only the style, but also the rhetoric, the way that this is done?
– Anzaldúa

Borderlands Rhetoric

- ▶ Embracing/employing/valuing multiple language practices.
- ▶ Embracing/employing/valuing cultural differences.
- ▶ Using writing and communication as a way of creating and negotiating identities.